

Raina has been an avid watcher of the popular series Bigg Boss. The events in the series, as per him, have helped him understand humans better. “What you realise eventually is that it is not about a person but all about the situation that a person is put in,” says Raina.

“You see celebrities do a lot of charity and stuff, but it is interesting to see how these celebrities react to different situations when put in different situations inside the Bigg Boss House. This is true of all human beings. Different situations make us react in different ways,” he adds.

But what separates great leaders from human beings, as per Raina, is the ability of these leaders staying true to themselves in every situation. “If you look at the likes of Mahatma Gandhi, Nelson Mandela, or Martin Luther King Jr, you will find that these leaders stayed the same irrespective of the situation they were in,” he explains.

He adds, “Such people stay true to their values in any and every situation, and this is where they ensure long-term success and respect for themselves. I think the path of greatness leads through a life where you respect your values more than anything else.”

Connecting the dots between books and leaders, he says, “All the successful people are similar fundamentally, but different methodologically. Similarly, most of the books I have read drive the same goal point but with different approaches. I think that the ways of achieving a goal can be different but the fundamental core of achieving any goal will always be the same.”

Politics and rajma chawal

Raina was active in politics as a student during his college years. It was a time when, as Raina recalls, having a girlfriend meant being able to talk to someone from the opposite sex in the college. He is more of an introvert and likes to keep a lot of things to himself. This interaction with him made it clear to me that being able to let him talk freely about his life would

be a difficult task, but once you befriend him, he could turn into that guy who is referred to as the soul of a party.

“I think it is because of my job that I have learned to open up with people. Apart from being active in politics during my college days, I was always on the introvert side,” he says.

For the record, he holds a BSc in electronics from Jammu, which he completed in five years. Not because he flunked exams or performed poorly, but because the violence in Kashmir had its effects on Jammu as well, and the exams for graduation those days kept being postponed one year after the other. This also gave him an opportunity to be more active in politics. As a matter of fact, there was a time when Raina was considering a career in politics.

“I was also into student politics and was a member of a student’s political organisation during my college days. I was the one organising student rallies and a lot of those things. I was very serious about politics as a career that time. But then, bread and butter issues have the capability of breaking any dream,” he shares smilingly.

It was at this point in the conversation that we stumbled upon our mutual love for India’s extraordinary dish called rajma chawal, and this dish happens to be Raina’s go-to favourite, no matter what his mood. Even now, he enjoys the dish every Sunday. And not just any rajma, the only rajma he enjoys eating are the ones sourced from Jammu and Kashmir. If you have ever tasted Kashmiri rajma, you would know the difference between the rest of the variants of the same dish from different parts of the country.

The first job and continuation of rajma chawal

Raina’s first job was with Hughes Telecom. He was placed in Bombay (now Mumbai) as assistant manager of the company’s marketing department. While the interesting story of how he landed this job follows after a few

paragraphs, the next few lines explain how much he loved rajma chawal back then and continues to love enjoying the dish even now.

“I never knew how to cook and still do not know how to, and it was a big challenge in the initial days. But fortunately, I found a dhaba in Bombay that was run by an individual from Jammu. It was for two years that I ate nothing else but rajma chawal for lunch. The guy running the dhaba became so aware of my choice that he stopped asking my order and would straight away bring a glass of water and rajma chawal as soon as I sat on one of the tables. The rajma chawal served at that dhaba was the Kashmiri version and hence I was able to enjoy it for two straight years,” Raina shares about his love for the dish.

Raina shared a room with four unknown guys in order to survive in Bombay during his first job. Fresh out of his MBA college, he was appearing for interviews in different cities, travelling by public transport, and sleeping in dharamshalas and gurdwaras—another chapter of his life that let him meet new people and interact with them. The story of his interview at Hughes Telecom, and getting placed there, is also as interesting as the part where he enjoyed rajma chawal for two years.

He went to Hughes Telecom for a walk-in interview that he saw being advertised in a newspaper, but was asked to leave after the group discussion round. Thinking that he was not able to impress the company, he continued with the process of giving interviews at other companies. Mobile phones at that time were a luxury, and all that the world relied on for communication were landlines. Everywhere Raina went for an interview, he left the landline number owned by his landlord.

One day, his landlord called him and told that a company had called and wanted to speak to him about offering Raina a job, but as destiny would have it, the landlord was not able to